

The Freshman Recruiting Timeline

The most common thing I hear from sophomores is some version of: "I didn't know it started this early." For finance, consulting, and a growing share of tech and marketing roles, the people who land internships in sophomore and junior summer started building toward them in freshman year. Not by applying to everything, but by doing a few boring things consistently.

STEP 1

Fall quarter: build the foundation

- Write a one-page resume, even if it's thin. High school leadership, jobs, and projects count right now.
- Pick one or two fields to explore. You don't need to be sure. You need a direction.
- Set up LinkedIn with a real photo and a clear headline.
- Record yourself answering "tell me about yourself." Watch it. It will be uncomfortable. That's the point.

STEP 2

Winter quarter: start talking to people

- Build a list of 50 companies in your field, including small and local firms, not just the famous names.
- Send personalized emails to people at those companies. Aim for a steady weekly number, not a burst.
- Every call gets a thank-you note within two hours and a line in your tracker.
- Apply to freshman and sophomore programs: early-insight days, diversity programs, and local internships.

STEP 3

Spring quarter: turn conversations into opportunities

- Follow up with the people you spoke to in winter. Share something you learned or did.
- Ask for referrals once you have a real relationship, not on the first call.
- Prepare six behavioral stories: leadership, teamwork, failure, conflict, initiative, and why this field.
- Say yes to the small internship. A first role at a local firm makes the second role much easier.

Recruiting doesn't reward the smartest student. It rewards the one who sent the 40th email, followed up on time, and practiced out loud. That's a habit, and habits can be built in a single year.